

Negotiation Skills			
Course Title	Negotiation Skills		
Course Language	English	Hours	3 Hrs. Total

Description:

Negotiation is not just about discussing prices. it is a vital communication process that helps you reach agreements benefiting all parties involved.

In freelancing, strong negotiation skills can make the difference between working for fair pay with clear terms or ending up with unclear expectations and extra unpaid work.

This session will guide you step-by-step on how to avoid common mistakes, communicate confidently, and choose the right strategy depending on the situation.

You will learn how to present your value to clients, set healthy boundaries, and handle difficult conversations while maintaining professionalism.

By the end of this session, you will understand how to achieve agreements that are fair, sustainable, and lead to long-term client relationships.

Course Objectives:

- Define negotiation and explain its role in professional success.
- Identify common negotiation mistakes and strategies to avoid them.
- Understand the differences between freelancing and traditional job negotiations.
- Apply effective freelance negotiation strategies, including pricing and client management.
- Use Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix to choose the right negotiation approach.
- Demonstrate good negotiation practices through role-play and case studies.
- Handle different types of challenging clients with professionalism.
- Recognize when and why to offer free services without undervaluing work.

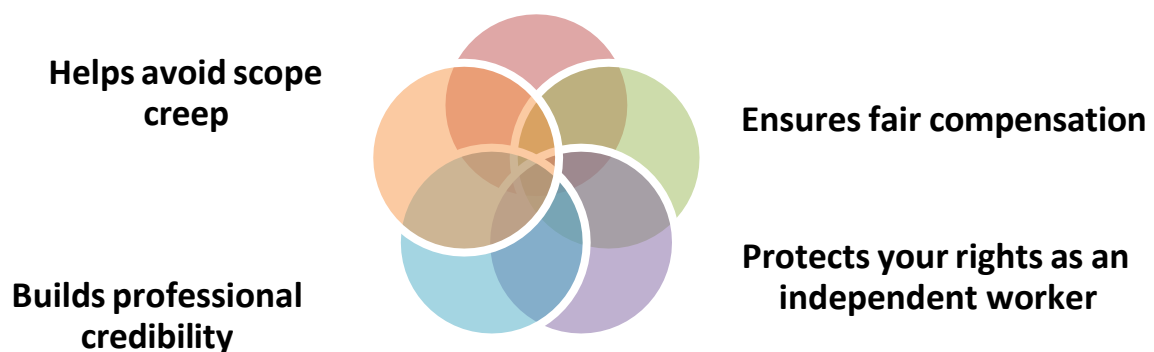
Module 1: Introduction to Negotiation Content of the Module: • What is Negotiation? • Why Negotiation is Essential for Freelancers • Unlearning Negotiation Missteps	1 Hrs.
Module 2: Freelancing vs Traditional Job Negotiation	15 mins.
Module 3: Effective Freelance Negotiation Strategies	15 mins.
Module 4: Goals & Strategies in Negotiation Content of the Module: • Key Goals of a Good Negotiation • Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix Goals	30 mins.
Module 5: How to Be a Good Negotiator Content of the Module: • Tips to Be a Good Negotiator (Especially for Freelancers) • Do's and Don'ts in Negotiation	30 mins.
Module 6: Special Considerations Content of the Module: • Free Services: When and Why?? • Different types of difficult Clients Behaviors	30 mins.

Module One: Introduction to Negotiation

What is Negotiation?

Negotiation is a communication process between two or more parties aiming to reach an agreement that benefits all sides. It involves offering, compromising, and finding solutions that work for everyone. For freelancers, negotiation ensures fair pay, protects rights, avoids scope creep, and builds professional credibility. Common mistakes to avoid include saying 'yes' too quickly, focusing only on price, overpromising, being too rigid, not getting agreements in writing, and taking rejection personally.

Why Negotiation is Essential for Freelancers



Unlearning Negotiation Missteps

Common mistakes freelancers make when negotiating and how to avoid them.



1. Thinking Negotiation = Price Only

Mistake: Believing that negotiation is only about lowering or raising the price.

Unlearn it: Negotiation includes time, scope, deadlines, revisions, payment terms, and more. Focus on the whole deal, not just the money.

2. Saying "Yes" Too Quickly

Mistake: Accepting the first offer without thinking or discussing it.

Unlearn it: Always take a moment to evaluate. Ask questions, and offer options. A pause shows professionalism, not hesitation.

3. Being Afraid to Ask for More

Mistake: Feeling scared or shy to ask for fair pay or better terms.

Unlearn it: You're offering value. Asking for what you deserve is not rude — it's professional.

4. Overpromising Just to Win the Project

Mistake: Agreeing to do more than you can handle, just to impress the client.

Unlearn it: It's better to under-promise and over-deliver. Be realistic. Set clear limits.

5. Being Too Rigid

Mistake: Refusing to compromise at all.

Unlearn it: Negotiation is about give and take. Find win-win solutions where both you and the client feel satisfied.

6. Not Getting Things in Writing

Mistake: Relying on verbal agreements or casual messages.

Unlearn it: Always confirm the final agreement (price, scope, deadline) in writing — even in a simple email or message.

7. Taking Rejection Personally

Mistake: Feeling upset or discouraged if a client says no.

Unlearn it: Rejection is normal. Learn from it and move on. It's about fit, not failure.

Module Two: Freelancing vs Traditional Job Negotiation

Freelancing negotiations differ from traditional jobs in several ways: Representation (self vs HR), direct vs indirect communication, flexibility of terms, pricing control, negotiable task assignments, client choice, and revision negotiations.

Aspect	Traditional Jobs	Freelancing
Representation	HR personnel or manager	You represent yourself
Client/Employer Communication	Usually indirect	Direct with the client
Flexibility of Terms	Fixed in a formal contract	Flexible (you can accept, reject, or modify)
Pricing	Predefined by the company	You set the price based on value and project
Task Assignment	Fixed and assigned by management	Negotiable per client and project
Negotiation on Revisions	Rare – based on company policy	Common – requires a clear agreement
Client Choice	None – you're bound to the company	Full – you choose whom you work with

Module Three: Effective Freelance Negotiation Strategies

Strategies include offering three-tier pricing (Basic, Standard, Premium), using your portfolio to justify rates, knowing when to say 'no' professionally, and managing pushy or indecisive clients calmly with clear options.



One of the most effective ways to handle pricing objections is to offer three service packages:

- **Basic:** A simple, affordable option for clients with tight budgets.
- **Standard:** A balanced package with good value and features.
- **Premium:** A full-featured offer with extras and priority service.

This approach does two things:

1. **Puts you in control** of the pricing conversation.
2. **Makes the client feel like they have a choice** — not a take-it-or-leave-it offer.

Many clients will choose the middle package, which is often your ideal price point.

1. Using your portfolio to support your rate

Clients may hesitate to pay more unless they see **proof of quality**.

Your portfolio should:

- Be clear, visual, and specific to the service you're offering.
- Include before/after examples or client results (if available).

Use your portfolio **as a negotiation tool**, like this:

"Here's a similar project I completed — it had a budget of \$100. As you can see, the quality and detail justify the cost."

Let your work speak for itself. A strong portfolio often **reduces the need for negotiation**.

2. Knowing when to say "no" without losing the client

Many beginners fear saying "no" because they think they'll lose the client — but saying no **professionally** can actually build trust.

You can say no by:

- **Offering an alternative:**
"I can't do that within 2 days, but I can deliver a high-quality version in 4."
- **Explaining the value:**
"That price is lower than what I usually charge, because I put a lot of detail into each design."

Saying no is about setting limits without sounding rude. If done respectfully, most serious clients will respect your boundaries.

3. Handling pushy or indecisive clients

Not all clients are easy to deal with — some are demanding, vague, or constantly changing their minds.

As a freelancer, your role is to:

- Stay **calm and polite** (don't take it personally).
- Ask **clarifying questions** to bring structure:
"Do you prefer Option A or B?"
"Can you confirm which version you'd like me to use?"

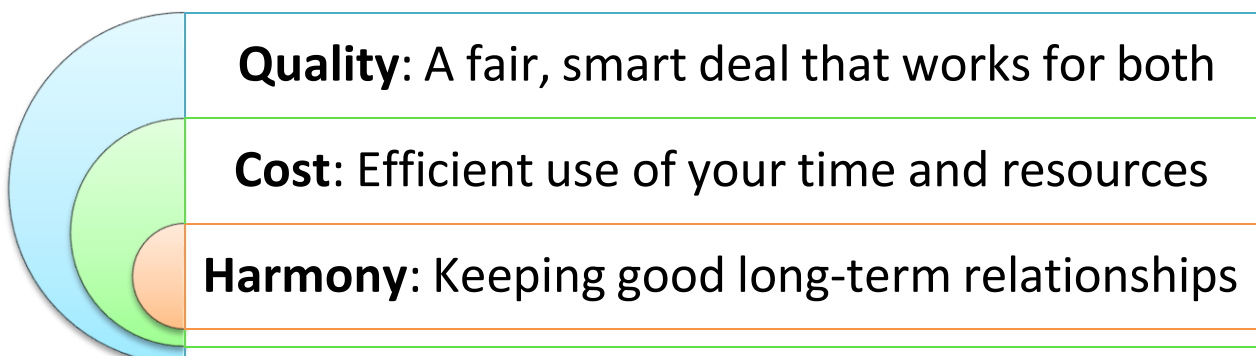
Give the client limited but clear choices. When they feel overwhelmed, help them focus.

This shows that you're not just a freelancer — you're a problem-solver.

Module Four: Goals & Strategies in Negotiation

Good negotiations aim for quality, cost efficiency, and harmony in relationships. Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix outlines five strategies: Competing (Win-Lose), Accommodating (Lose-Win), Avoiding (Lose-Lose), Compromising (Partial Win-Win), and Collaborating (Win-Win).

Key Goals of a Good Negotiation



Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix Goals

In any negotiation, two important goals should always be considered. you choose your negotiation strategy based on two factors.

The importance of the outcome:

how important substantive results are, such as money, time, accomplishment, etc.

The importance of the relationship:

how important relational outcomes are, such as building or maintaining your relationship with the counterparty

Lewicki and Hiam's Negotiation Matrix is a tool that helps you choose the best negotiation strategy.

The matrix consists of **five negotiation strategies**:

1. Competing
2. Accommodating
3. Avoiding
4. Compromising
5. Collaborating



- **Competing (Win-Lose)**

his strategy focuses on **achieving the best possible outcome for yourself**, even if it means the other party loses. It is often used when the outcome is critical, and maintaining the relationship is not a priority.

- **Accommodating (Lose-Win)**

Here, you **prioritize the relationship** over the outcome, often giving in to the other party's demands. While this helps maintain goodwill, it comes at the cost of not achieving the best possible result for yourself.

- **Avoiding (Lose-Lose)**

In this case, neither party **achieves a favorable outcome** because the issue is ignored or postponed indefinitely. It is typically used when the negotiation is not worth the effort or when both sides prefer to avoid conflict.

- **Compromising (Partial Win-Win)**

This approach seeks a **middle ground** where both parties **make concessions**. While neither side gets everything they want, both gain something, making it a fair but not optimal solution.

- **Collaborating (Win-Win)**

The ideal strategy is when **both the outcome and the relationship are important**.

It involves working together to find a solution that satisfies both parties' interests, ensuring mutual success.

- **Activity: Negotiation Coach Interaction**

Now that you know the five strategies of Lewicki and Hiam's Matrix, use an AI assistant as your personal negotiation coach. Paste a real client message and let the coach draft your reply and name the strategy behind it. Replace the text between brackets with your own details before sending the prompt.

"Act as an expert Freelance Negotiation Coach. I will provide: - My freelance service: [your service] - My experience level: [Beginner / Intermediate / Advanced] - The client's message: [paste the client's reply] Based on professional freelance negotiation principles, generate: 1. The best professional reply to the client. 2. Explain why this is the best response. 3. Identify the negotiation strategy used (Collaborating, Compromising, Competing, Accommodating, or Avoiding). 4. If appropriate, suggest a better offer (pricing, scope, deadline, revisions, or package). 5. If the client asks for a discount, recommend how to respond without undervaluing my work. 6. If the client has a low budget, suggest a win-win alternative instead of simply accepting or rejecting. 7. If the client requests urgent delivery, explain whether an extra fee should be charged and how to communicate it professionally. 8. Point out any negotiation mistakes I should avoid. 9. Rewrite the response in a confident, friendly, and client-focused tone."

Module Five: How to Be a Good Negotiator

Best practices: know your value, be clear about offers, listen first, communicate confidently without aggression, delay accepting first offers, provide multiple packages, set deadlines, and walk away when needed. Do's: prepare, listen, set goals, be flexible, communicate respectfully, control emotions. Don'ts: rush, focus only on price, be too rigid, ignore body language, skip written agreements, take rejection personally.

➤ Tips to Be a Good Negotiator (Especially for Freelancers)

Know Your Value

Understand what your skills are worth and don't accept very low rates just to get the job.

Be Clear About What You Offer

Clearly explain what the client will receive, including the scope of work and number of revisions.

Listen First

Let the client share their needs and expectations before you start discussing money or deadlines.

Communicate with Confidence, Not Aggression

Be calm and respectful while standing up for your value. Confidence builds trust.

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Don't Accept the First Offer Immediately

Take time to think. It's okay to say "Let me review and get back to you."

Offer Options

Provide 2–3 service packages (Basic, Standard, Premium) to give the client flexibility.

Set Clear Deadlines and Expectations

Be realistic about delivery time and avoid overpromising.

Be Willing to Walk Away

If the deal is not fair or doesn't feel right, it's okay to say no professionally.

➤ Do's and Don'ts in Negotiation



Dos	Don'ts
Prepare thoroughly Research the client and know your value.	Accept or reject too quickly Don't rush your decision but take time to evaluate.
Listen actively Understand the client's needs and concerns.	Focus only on price Negotiation is also about deadlines, revisions, and terms.
Set clear goals Know what you want and what you can compromise on.	Be too rigid Being inflexible can break the deal.
Be flexible Look for win-win solutions and stay open-minded.	Ignore body language Non-verbal cues are part of communication.
Communicate clearly and respectfully Use polite, professional language.	Forget to document agreements Always get the final terms in writing.
Control your emotions Stay calm and professional even under pressure.	Take things personally Rejection is part of the process, not a failure.

Module Six: Special Considerations

Free services can be useful for building a portfolio, attracting clients, or demonstrating value, but avoid if they devalue your work, are unsustainable, or lack client commitment. Difficult clients include perfectionist, defensive, aggressive, complaining, and arrogant types. each requiring tailored handling. Case studies: Low budget (offer simpler version), urgent delivery (charge extra), unclear brief (ask for details).

Free Services: When and Why?



When to Offer Free Services

- Building Your Portfolio
- Attracting Clients
- Demonstrating Value



When Not to Offer Free Services

- Devaluing Your Work
- Unsustainable Practice
- Lack of Commitment

When to Offer Free Services:

1. **Building Your Portfolio:** When starting out, offering free services can help you gain experience and showcase your work.
2. **Attracting Clients:** Free trials or samples can entice potential clients to consider your services.
3. **Demonstrating Value:** Providing a free service can demonstrate your skills and the quality of your work.

When Not to Offer Free Services:

1. **Devaluing Your Work:** Consistently offering free services may lead clients to undervalue your expertise.
2. **Unsustainable Practice:** Regularly working for free is not a sustainable business model.
3. **Lack of Commitment:** Clients who receive free services may not be as committed or serious.

Different types of difficult Clients Behaviors

• Interactive Session: Freelancing Negotiation Scenarios

In this interactive session (hosted on Mentimeter, Wordwall, or Microsoft Teams) you will work through real-time client management scenarios and decide how you would respond to each one. For every scenario, identify the negotiation strategy you would use from Lewicki and Hiam's Matrix, then compare your answer with the group.

4. The client changes the project timeline after the work has already started.
5. The client requests additional work that is outside the agreed scope.
6. The client asks for an introductory discount on the first project.
7. The client presents an extremely limited budget for the work required.

Client Type	Traits	Freelancer Tips (How to Deal)
Perfectionist Client	Obsesses over every detail, struggles to prioritize, aims for unrealistic perfection which may delay progress.	▪ Avoid assigning them projects with tight deadlines or flexible scopes. ▪ Gently highlight the behavior and its downsides. ▪ Help them focus on priorities and key outcomes. ▪ Be sensitive when giving feedback & avoid direct criticism.
Defensive Client	Takes feedback personally, reacts negatively to suggestions or constructive criticism, which can slow collaboration.	▪ Start conversations with positives. ▪ Focus on the issue, not the person - depersonalize it. ▪ Avoid blame-oriented language. ▪ Show empathy and understanding.
Aggressive Client	Attacks ideas or people, blames others, displays anger, hostility, or dominance in communication.	▪ Stay calm and don't react emotionally. ▪ Address the group (if in a call), not just the individual. ▪ Remain neutral and composed. ▪ Try to find common ground.
Complaining Client	Constantly finds faults, blames others, dismisses suggestions but offers no solutions or alternatives.	▪ Ask clarifying questions to dig into real issues. ▪ Don't get defensive or retaliate. ▪ Shift the focus to problem-solving. ▪ Set clear timelines and shared decision points.
Arrogant Client	Overconfident, controlling, believes they always know best, often dismissive of others' input.	▪ Show that trusting others can still lead to great results. ▪ Know your stuff — be confident and factual. ▪ Acknowledge parts of their ideas. ▪ Use "we" language. ▪ Set clear boundaries for collaboration.

